India is building dams, too, to meet its growing needs for electricity: first in Bhutan and Nepal and now in Arunachal Pradesh. Revenue from the sale of electricity from dams built by India in Bhutan provides the Himalayan kingdom with a substantial source of income that has been used for the country's development. In Nepal, India has become the largest hydropower developer as well, most recently with an agreement signed in November 2014 to build a 900-megawatt dam and power station in the eastern part of the country. In August, Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi signed a deal with the Nepalese for the first 900-megawatt dam, in western Nepal. The deals are not without controversy and some politicians and NGOs are demanding they be terminated.[13]

Hydroelectric development in Arunachal is also controversial. The state has a tremendous potential for generating electricity, and all its rivers flow down into the lowlands of Assam below the mountains. Construction of a dam on the Siang River, a tributary of the Brahmaputra that flows through Arunachal's Upper Siang District, began in April 2009 and, when completed, it will be the largest hydroelectric dam in the Indian subcontinent. In 2010, a local student organization appealed to the Indian government to scrap the Siang project and other dams that it has plans to build in Arunachal. The government responded by saying that the projects will not be cancelled and that necessary precautions will be undertaken to ensure minimal environmental impact.[14]

It is inevitable that those huge projects on the rivers flowing south from the Himalayas will adversely affect the environment. But there is a fundamental difference between hydroelectric power development in India and China. India is a democracy where such issues can be discussed freely, and it is legitimate to protest the government's decisions and plans. This is not the case in China. The suspension of the Salween dams was a rare exception, but was possible because some of Green Watershed's organizers have high-level contacts and, therefore, some protection for their activities.

But India's strength, its democracy, also makes it vulnerable to unwanted, internal pressures. Protests against the plans to build dams in Arunachal have been exploited by India's Maoists. The Communist Party of India-Maoist (CPI-Maoist), which is engaged in armed insurrection against the Indian state, may be an unlawful organization, but it operates openly through a number of civil society groups and other fronts. Anti-dam activists have stalled the construction of a dam on the Subansiri River since